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Echoes of Silence and the Story of Many: The Transmission of Intergenerational Trauma in Elizabeth Strout's *My Name is Lucy Barton*

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ABSTRACT
Elizabeth Strout's *My Name is Lucy Barton* (2016) explores a fragile mother-daughter relationship through the lens of a traumatic past involving poverty, abuse and maternal coldness. Strout portrays the mother-daughter relationship in an ambivalent way. Despite emotional distance and even neglect, Strout reveals an enduring and deep bond between mother and daughter. I will adopt a psychoanalytic approach to explore the impact of intergenerational trauma on a daughter's psychological and emotional development by examining how a traumatic/troubled past simultaneously becomes a space for escaping/forgetting and returning/remembering.

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The mother-daughter bond is often foundational, shaping a daughter's identity through shared culture, history and the transmission of the conceptions of womanhood and motherhood across generations. This multifaceted connection encompasses not only direct relationships but also those marked by absence, abandonment or early maternal loss. Daughters shape their identities by adopting, adapting or rejecting maternal values and experiences, even in the mother's minimal presence or complete absence. John Bowlby's attachment theory provides a psychological framework for understanding how early attachment with the mother or a mother substitute influences a daughter's self-development. Bowlby argues that "[w]hat is believed to be essential for mental health is that the infant and young child should experience a warm, intimate and continuous relationship with his mother (or permanent mother-substitute) in which both find satisfaction and enjoyment".[1] Beyond her biological role, the mother is a crucial psychological and relational figure whose emotional availability significantly shapes identity formation. Crucially, this framework extends to cases of maternal absence due to abandonment, death or other circumstances, where daughters may still inherit trauma through mechanisms like family silences, social norms, patriarchy or institutional structures that bear the imprint of this absence. Italian philosopher Luisa Muraro suggests that "a woman [...] always remains the daughter of her mother, so that every natural mother is already a

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[1]Bowlby, *Attachment and Loss*, xi–ii.

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substitute"[2], highlighting a continuous maternal lineage that transcends individual interactions. This inheritance includes not only cultural and historical knowledge but also intergenerational trauma, particularly when the maternal bond is damaged or characterised by silence, neglect and unresolved pain. Maternal absence may become an invisible presence that shapes daughters' emotional development, showing how trauma persists across generations regardless of the mother's physical presence or absence.

These theoretical insights into intergenerational trauma are explored in Elizabeth Strout's *My Name is Lucy Barton* (2016), which examines the complex dynamics of such trauma and tension within the mother-daughter relationship. Strout traces this bond's impact through Lucy's fragmented recollections, spanning her emotionally deprived childhood, her mother's hospital visit in the mid-1980s, her journey of becoming a writer, and her life in the 2000s after her mother's death. The novel explores this relationship through the lens of a traumatic past defined by poverty, abuse and maternal coldness. Strout portrays the mother-daughter bond as deeply ambivalent: an enduring connection persists despite emotional distance and neglect.

Scholarship on Strout's work extensively analyses her exploration of trauma, family dysfunction, psychological distress and emotional healing. For instance, Katherine Montwieler's *A Companion to the Works of Elizabeth Strout* comprehensively examines trauma, maternal bonds, and identity formation. Montwieler points out how Strout's characters grapple with past traumas, highlighting the complexities of family ties and the enduring influence of childhood experiences and traumas on psychological development and identity. Similarly, Qui Minghui's "Strout's Insight into the Times: Trauma and Recovery in *Olive Kitteridge*" analyses the protagonist Olive Kitteridge's psychological trauma, its underlying causes and methods of healing. Minghui examines how Olive's relationships and inner struggle reflect past experiences, family dysfunction, and PTSD related to 9/11. While this scholarship offers a sophisticated analysis of Strout's exploration of trauma and emotional recovery, this essay takes a complementary yet distinct approach by narrowing its focus to the formative impact of early maternal attachment on the daughter's identity.

Drawing on a psychoanalytic framework such as John Bowlby's attachment theory and Margaret Mahler's separation-individuation theory, I will examine the long-lasting psychological consequences of insecure maternal attachment in childhood. I further explore how the transmission of intergenerational trauma shapes the daughter's evolving identity, and how a traumatic/troubled past simultaneously becomes a space for escaping/forgetting and returning/remembering. Rather than following a chronological order, my analysis mirrors the novel's fragmented narrative structure and reflects the non-linear temporality of trauma. It traces the re-emergence of Lucy's childhood trauma during her hospitalisation, exploring the past as a dynamic space of both forgetting and remembering and demonstrating how writing provides a space for artistic expression and self-healing. Thus, I will analyse how Strout constructs intergenerational trauma as both fragmenting and generative—disrupting Lucy's sense of self while simultaneously giving rise to her voice.

Strout establishes this complex dynamic through the novel's opening scene-setting in which the symbolic values of names are important for understanding trauma and the

[2]Muraro, *The Symbolic Order of the Mother*, 52.

mother-daughter relationship. A symbolic connection exists between the titular character Lucy and the Chrysler Building, visible from her hospital room during her nine-week recovery following her appendectomy. At night, the building is lit up, and Lucy sees it as a beacon of hope. This hopeful symbolism is emphasised by Lucy's name, derived from the Latin *Lucianus* (a derivative of the Roman *Lucius*), meaning light.[3] Lucy, whose name embodies light, metaphorically excavates and illuminates her dark past marked by unspoken trauma, grief, poverty and abuse through memories and conversations with her mother. As Katherine Montwieler puts it, "the lights of the Chrysler Building illuminate Lucy's consciousness, providing her as much hope as any eastern star offers others. [...] New York gives her the freedom if not exactly to escape her past at least to grow into her own consciousness".[4] Montwieler further notes that "'Barton' resonates symbolically as well, referring to a 'farmyard,' like the kind where Lucy grew up".[5] Thus, Lucy Barton's full name signifies a complex connection to both light and grounded, painful origins. The Chrysler Building embodies a crucial duality: its nocturnal symbolic beauty is ephemeral, receding during the daytime to become "remote, silent, far away"[6] like other city buildings. This temporal dichotomy between light and dark reveals a paradox: beauty and hope may emerge from darkness. Hence, this paradoxical situation suggests that Lucy's healing requires confronting, rather than escaping, her traumatic past of poverty, abuse and maternal disaffection. This oscillation between nocturnal hope and daytime remoteness parallels Lucy's relationship with her mother, who similarly oscillates between physical presence and emotional unavailability. The Chrysler Building's ephemeral beauty thus reflects the ambivalent nature of intergenerational trauma and healing: hope exists, but the darkness needs to be illuminated. This indicates that healing involves reconciliation with inherited trauma rather than mere overcoming of it. Indeed, confronting the darkness of her childhood highlights the intergenerational transmission of trauma. When recalling her childhood, Lucy observes that "on occasion and without warning, my parents—and it was usually my mother and usually in the presence of our father—struck us impulsively and vigorously".[7] This demonstrates neither the home nor the family provides the safe, loving and emotionally secure space children are expected to experience.

The novel explores how parental neglect and physical violence create an intergenerational cycle of anxiety, insecurity and fear of abandonment. Lucy's brother and parents are unnamed in the novel. They are the embodiment of undefined and unspoken trauma. According to John Bowlby's attachment theory, children who do not receive consistent and emotionally sensitive childcare in infancy develop an "anxious avoidant pattern"[8] with their mothers. Those who showed this pattern "are likely to be described later as emotionally insulated, hostile or antisocial, and as unduly seeking attention"[9] and show "signs of helplessness and defeatism".[10] Lucy's brother is a striking example of the long-term psychological effects of maternal insecure attachment. At the age of 36,

[3]"Lucy". (n.d) Online Etymology Dictionary.
[4]Montwieler, *A Companion to the Works of Elizabeth Strout*, 109.
[5]Ibid., 109.
[6]Strout, *My Name is Lucy Barton*, 3.
[7]Ibid., 12.
[8]Bowlby, *A Secure Base*, 167.
[9]Ibid., 167.
[10]Ibid., 167.

he still lives with the family and sleeps next to the livestock destined for the slaughterhouse the next day. This behaviour shows how much he identifies with the animal. It suggests a deeply insecure man who wishes to take comfort from and, in turn, offer comfort to a vulnerable animal, and it hints at some deep trauma and lack of physical and emotional comfort in his past. Strout portrays Lucy's brother as a devastating example of how early trauma and insecure attachment can prevent emotional maturity and development. Lucy learns her brother still reads children's books and questions this: "[w]hat was it in them that my brother liked? The family of this series was a nice family. They made their way across the prairie, they were sometimes in trouble, but always the mother was kind and the father loved them very much".[11] The family he admires and idealises is an allusion to Laura Ingalls Wilder's *House on the Prairie* which depicts the Ingalls family's love for one another, maternal kindness and paternal devotion in the face of adversity. Like Lucy, he looks for a family that can only be found in the annals of literature to find the emotional security and belonging they cannot find in the real world.

Lucy, too, is not securely attached to her mother; metaphorically she feels homeless and seeks her mother's love. When her mother comes to the hospital room and calls her 'Wizzle', her pet name, she suddenly "feels warm and liquid-filled".[12] Despite years of separation, neither knows how to navigate this unexpected intimacy. This intimate nickname thus functions not only as a means of communication but also as a bridge for nurturing emotions and deepening the mother-daughter bond. As Alison Stone argues, language "mediates our experience and our relationships with the mother, and with others. [...] The function of language, then, is not to displace but to extend the mother-child bond".[13] This intimate language creates a common shared space that deepens the bond between the mother and the daughter.

The visit Lucy's mother pays her in hospital offers her a momentary opportunity for reconnection. Instead of confrontation, she reverts to a child-like state. Her mother's use of her childhood nickname triggers a return to a shared childhood intimacy which transcends and avoids the awkwardness of adulthood and its accompanying alienation and distance. Lucy wants to create a safe space that never existed: "my mother started telling me stories of people she had known years before. [...] Sometimes I dozed off, and when I woke I would beg her to talk again. But she said, Oh, Wizzle-dee, you need your rest. [...] I am resting! Please, Mom. Tell me something. Tell me anything".[14] While storytelling generally strengthens emotional bonds and secure attachment between a mother and a child, Lucy's attempts to use their shared childhood hopefully as a doorway into exploring her neglected and abusive past are met with maternal refusal. Her mother avoids genuine connection and remains silent about their past by telling stories of others. This avoidance and inability to address their family's past represents how patriarchal structures silence women. The mother's role as a 'silent endurer'—"most wives did in that generation"[15]—highlights the broader cultural and political forces demanding feminine silence. Her emotional detachment, then, is not only psychological

[11]Strout, *My Name is Lucy Barton*, 73.
[12]Ibid., 7.
[13]Stone, "Foreword", x.
[14]Strout, *My Name is Lucy Barton*, 10.
[15]Ibid., 107.

but also politically and culturally constructed. As a result, Lucy and her mother remained strangers to each other and are unable to establish a strong, emotionally connected mother-daughter relationship. Nevertheless, Lucy longs to create a bond with her mother. If this cannot be achieved through words as communication, it might be achieved through words as sonic comfort. She asks her mother to keep talking: "It was the sound of my mother's voice I most wanted; what she said didn't matter. And so I listened to the sound of her voice".[16]

Throughout the hospital visit, the room itself offers a liminal space of hope and understanding, an opportunity to close the emotional distance between mother and daughter through Lucy's childhood memories and her mother's storytelling. Yet the hospital room also represents the paradoxes of sickness and healing, symbolising the paradoxical, conflict-laden relationship between mother and daughter. While surgical removal of an appendix is relatively straightforward, Lucy develops severe post-operative complications requiring a lengthy stay as an in-patient. This could symbolically speak to an underlying trauma so deep that it cannot easily be healed by conventional means. Medical scientist Luis Vitetta has explored possible links between appendicitis and depression. He notes that "reports of a surgically removed chronically inflamed vermiform appendix have been linked to chronic disease developed including depression".[17] Although Lucy's case involves post-operative complications rather than prior chronic inflammation, the inflamed appendix here figuratively appears connected to Lucy's buried childhood trauma. Like her suppressed childhood trauma, which also surfaces in extreme conditions, the appendix is often unrecognised until it causes a problem. Lucy's medical condition can thus be interpreted as a bodily manifestation of long-unacknowledged emotional distress.

The removal of her infected appendix brings temporary physical relief, yet the post-operative complications symbolise Lucy's deeper, unhealed emotional and psychological wounds. As Lucy herself realises, "it was not the scar trying to keep [her] sick".[18] During this extended sojourn in a hospital room, she seeks to confront her traumatic past and uncover the origins of her mother's unspoken trauma, illustrated in such actions as her taking catnaps sitting bolt upright as if unable to relax or let down her guard. Lucy gradually realises how her mother's anxiety, rooted in childhood trauma, has persisted into late adulthood: "she started, that morning, to suddenly speak of her childhood, how she had taken catnaps throughout her childhood too". "You learn to, when you don't feel safe," she said. "You can always take a catnap sitting up. I know very little about my mother's childhood".[19] This refusal to discuss her suffering reflects gendered expectations that women endure hardships silently. Though Lucy's mother verbally reveals little about her past, her alert, upright posture, even in sleep, eloquently conveys an unspoken trauma. As Peter Levine, developer of Somatic Experiencing®, a body-centred approach to trauma healing, notes, "traumatic memories are fixed and static. They are imprints (engrams) from past overwhelming experiences, deep impressions carved into the sufferer's brain, body and psyche".[20] Her mother's trauma has left a

[16]Ibid., 89.
[17]Vitetta, et al. "The Brain–Intestinal Mucosa-Appendix- Microbiome- Brain Loop", 6.
[18]Strout, *My Name is Lucy Barton*,57.
[19]Ibid., 47.
[20]Levine, *Trauma and Memory: Brain and Body in a Search for the Living Past*, 24.

profound imprint on her body and consciousness, establishing a pattern for intergenerational trauma. The mother's emotional distance and inability to connect with her children thwart Lucy's constant desire for intimacy. Yet, this neglect is only one facet of Lucy's traumatic past. Lucy endures more blatant and horrific abuses from her father, creating lasting psychological damage.

Lucy vividly recalls her father locking her in his truck as punishment, a brutal experience she describes: "I remember pounding on the glass of the windows, screaming. [...] it was just terror, realizing that no one was to come, and watching the sky get darker, and feeling the cold start in. Always I screamed and screamed. I cried until I could hardly breathe".[21] This brutal treatment destroys the child's trust in the parent and family unit and leads to endless repercussions into adulthood. Lucy's terrifying experience in the truck, a space of existential fear and despair, echoes her mother's own childhood trauma. It is within this profound isolation and terror that Lucy's mind dissociates into fantasy as she recounts:

> My mind went very strange places during these episodes of being in the truck. I thought I saw a man coming toward me, I thought I saw a monster [...] Then I would calm myself, and say aloud to myself, "It's okay, sweetie. A nice woman's going to come soon. And you're a very good girl, you're such a good girl, and she's a relative of Mommy's and she'll need you to go live with her [...]" I would have this fantasy, and it was very real to me, it kept me calm.[22]

This excerpt illustrates how Lucy attempts to cope with trauma by creating an alternative world featuring a fantasy female saviour figure—a relative of her mother who embodies the nurturing qualities her actual mother lacks. This imagined relative functions as an idealised, nicer and more caring version of her own mother. What makes this passage particularly painful is that it reveals how Lucy unconsciously develops fantasies of nurturing and maternal warmth as a coping mechanism for domestic abuse. This fantasy of surrogate adult caring figures recurs at other points in the novel. For instance, while the doctor cares for her with paternal warmth, Lucy recalls how, as a child, she wanted desperately to run to a stranger and plead "[y]ou need to help me, please, please, can you please get me out of there, bad things are going on".[23] This quote reflects not merely an isolated moment, but a recurrent emotional state of profound distress. The word 'there' evokes not only Lucy's experience of being locked in the truck, but also the broader, emotionally fraught atmosphere of her family home, where pervasive 'bad things' occurred.

This atmosphere is further exemplified by the abusive behaviour of Lucy's father. He profoundly humiliates his son by forcing him to walk through town in drag while driving his truck alongside, shouting to passer-by that his son is a "fucking faggot and the world should know".[24] This brutal, machismo-laden humiliation not only damages the son but also traumatises Lucy, who witnesses the shameful spectacle. The truck's symbolism in this scene extends beyond Lucy's own punitive incarcerations; here, it explicitly functions as a symbol of masculine brutality crushing emotional sensitivity. This cruelty, however,

[21]Strout, *My Name is Lucy Barton,* 59.
[22]Ibid., 59–60.
[23]Ibid., 81.
[24]Ibid., 119.

is complicated by a later scene in which the father and son hug and cry together. This emotional shift from humiliation to tenderness illustrates the complexity of intergenerational trauma, revealing how expressions of violence and care often overlap. It suggests that Lucy's father, shaped by his own unresolved trauma, manifests his distress through both overt rage and conflicted acts of affection.

The truck is both literally a vehicle and a metaphor for sudden trauma. A particularly telling episode in the novel illustrates this through Lucy's attempts to explain to her mother how she was once locked inside her father's truck with a snake. Lucy's fragmented recollection reveals her ongoing struggle to articulate the experience:

> I wanted to say—oh, terribly I wanted to say: Not even when there was the really, really long brown snake in there with me one time? I wanted to ask her this, but I could not bear to say the word, even now I can barely stand to say the word, and to tell anyone how frightened I was when I saw that I had been locked into a truck with such a long brown— And he moved so quickly. So quickly.[25]

The dash after 'long brown' represents the blank space of trauma; Lucy is too traumatised to utter the word 'snake'. Instead, she fills the nominal gap with hurried adverbs and adjectives conveying sense impressions—speed, length 'really really long'. The prose style enacts and mirrors the trauma. This stuttering attempt at sharing trauma reflects Lucy's intense psychological distress. As psychiatrist Van der Kolk, known for his studies on the effects of trauma at different developmental stages, asserts "[...] traumatized people get stuck in the past: They become obsessed with the horror they consciously want to leave behind, but they keep behaving and feeling as if it is still going on".[26] Lucy's inability to fully articulate the 'snake' incident exemplifies this fixation, demonstrating how a past horror continues to define her present emotional state.

The snake incident, beyond its immediate psychological impact, reveals the archetypal dimensions of Lucy's trauma. Strout's use of the snake imagery, whether intentional or not, aligns with and illuminates Jungian archetypal patterns. Her work contextualises Jungian theory within rich emotional and narrative textures, which shows how trauma shapes symbolic expression, particularly when language fails. In Jungian archetypal criticism, the snake primarily represents "the unconscious psyche"[27] formed by hidden anxieties, fears, and (un)defined traumas. Jung suggests that "the unconscious insinuates itself in the form of a snake if the conscious mind is afraid of the compensating tendency of the unconscious, as is generally the case in regression".[28] Moreover, he refers to the snake as "a symbol of earth, which has always been considered feminine".[29] Within this framework, the snake in Lucy's experience represents the umbilical cord, symbolising the traumatic bond between Lucy and her mother, who transfers her sense of insecurity and emotional repression to her daughter. Thus, the snake's presence during Lucy's confinement in the truck symbolise primordial fear: existential anxiety and insecurity rooted in this familial dynamic. As psychologist and psychoanalyst Caroline Garland, who specialises in trauma studies highlights that in moments of intense trauma, "[p]rimitive fears, ones that reach back to infancy, are evoked. Symbolic

[25]Ibid., 67–8.
[26]Van der Kolk, "Foreword", 9–10.
[27]Jung, *Symbols of Transformation*, 607.
[28]Ibid., 608.
[29]Ibid.,172.

thought is replaced by unconsciously driven re-enactments of the trauma in flashbacks and nightmares. The distinction between the present and the past is eroded. There is a basic loss of trust: the external and internal worlds no longer feel safe. This is more than a mechanical breakdown; it is a collapse of meaning". [30] This traumatic disruption damages Lucy's emotional coherence and her ability to make sense of her experiences. It resurfaces through 'unconsciously driven re-enactments'—such as flashbacks and nightmares—that collapse the boundaries between past and present. This temporal disorientation contributes to a broader 'collapse of meaning', particularly within the mother-daughter relationship.

Elizabeth Strout expands on the complexities of maternal transmission by featuring several other mother-daughter relationships that illustrate how cultural heritage and emotional trauma are conveyed. These narratives, such as those of Lucy's friend Molla in the Village and her college roommate, share a background of maternal deprivation, reflecting and reinforcing Lucy's own experience. Lucy recalls Molla's postpartum depression, for instance, diagnosed by her psychiatrist as "grief because of everything she had not received from her own mother".[31] This instance implies how the lifelong mother-daughter bond, whether constructive or destructive, impacts the daughter's identity, sense of self, and future maternal roles. Similarly, Lucy's roommate, despite disliking her own mother, who had treated her badly, felt compelled to preserve a gift of cheese that her mother had given her. Lucy observes how this seemingly trivial object—the unwanted cheese—sheds light on the complexities of their troubled relationship:

> [N]either of us liked cheese, but my roommate could not throw it away, or even stand to give it away. "Do you mind?" she asked. "If we keep this somehow? I mean, my mother gave it to me." And I said I understood. She put the cheese on the outside windowsill and it stayed there, the snow falling on it eventually, and we both forgot about it, but there it was in the spring. In the end she arranged for me to dispose of it when she was in class, and I did.[32]

The unwanted cheese and the daughter's reluctance to throw it away signify the emotional gap between mother and daughter, a failed opportunity for them to connect. Her aversion to discarding the gift, despite her disinterest in it, shows that she fears losing even the slightest connection with her mother. Although she puts the cheese on the outside windowsill herself, she is unable to throw it away and has to get someone to do it for her. This reflects a daughter's emotional difficulty in breaking ties with her mother.

The daughter's retention of the cheese *from autumn to spring* may suggest an allusion to the seasonal myth of Demeter and Persephone, a mythical troubled mother-daughter relationship. This myth that describes the cyclical nature of seasons also reflects the cyclical nature of loss and reunion. While the spring symbolises Persephone's return to the earth and the reunion with her mother, for Lucy's roommate, it marks the moment to break even the most tenuous connection with the mother. The rotting cheese thus symbolises a distant, insecure mother-daughter relationship that will not heal. Rolla May, influential in existential psychotherapy, argues that myths act "as a framework for the discovery and unfolding of a sense of personal identity, proposing answers to the question

[30]Quoted in Marzillier's book, *The Trauma Therapies*, 46.
[31]Strout, *My Name is Lucy Barton*, 62.
[32]Ibid., 181.

'Who am I?'".[33] The myth of Demeter and Persephone also serves as a lens through which Lucy Barton's relationship with her mother can be understood, albeit one that diverges from the myth's conventional roles. The myth tells of Persephone's abduction by Hades to the underworld and how Demeter, the goddess of harvest, emotionally deprived of her daughter, yearns for her return and turns the Earth into a barren place in her absence. In the novel, themes of loss and separation are reflected in Lucy's relationship with her mother, yet with a crucial variation: Lucy's estrangement is not a physical abduction, but an emotional absence, stemming from her mother's withdrawal, likely rooted in unspoken trauma. As a child, Lucy yearns for the care and maternal love her mother withholds. In this sense, Lucy becomes a modern Persephone—not abducted by external forces, but isolated in an emotional underworld, perpetually longing for connection. Simultaneously, her desire for reunion mirrors Demeter's grief. Lucy does not fully embody either figure; instead, her emotional experience oscillates between that of a neglected daughter and a maternal figure longing for connection. This duality reflects the complexity of a strained mother-daughter relationship shaped by absence and longing. Strout's novel thus reimagines the myth as a psychological exploration of how maternal deprivation and unresolved trauma shape a daughter's inner world. For a daughter to achieve autonomy, the silences and emotional gaps between the mother and daughter must be acknowledged.

Lucy attempts to bridge the emotional gap by initiating a sincere conversation about her literary achievements, telling her mother that two of her stories have been published. Her mother's silence and failure to acknowledge Lucy's success erode her self-confidence and highlight a generational inability to affirm female achievement. The fact that Lucy still expects her mother's appreciation, despite being an adult and a mother herself, reveals an enduring mother-daughter bond. Writing becomes Lucy's vital outlet to assuage her loneliness: "[t]his is my point. And I thought: I will write and people will not feel so alone!".[34] For Lucy, writing becomes more than self-expression; it functions as an act of creating a shared space, a communal experience that counters individual isolation. Lucy, a neglected child deprived of her mother's affection, feels a deep and existential loneliness: "Lonely was the first flavor I had tasted in my life, and it was always there, hidden inside the crevices of my mouth, reminding me".[35] Daughters who do not develop a strong, secure maternal bond in childhood often carry (un)spoken resentments, which may manifest as a desire to distance themselves from their mother's image. Lucy observes this in her plastic surgeon's waiting room:

> Women, and a few men, sit in the waiting room for the doctor who will make them look not old or worried or like their mother. A few years ago I went there to not look like my mother. The doctor said that almost everyone came in the first time and said they looked like their mother and didn't want to. [...] Usually it was the mother—or the father— that people didn't want to look like, often both, she said, but mostly it was the mother.[36]

This effort not to resemble the mother is a psychological rejection that reflects an inner struggle to resist the mother's influence and a deeper fear of becoming like one's own

[33]May, *The Cry for Myth*, 30–1.
[34]Strout, *My Name is Lucy Barton*, 24.
[35]Ibid., 41–2.
[36]Ibid., 129.

parents. The novel thus presents a complex mother-daughter dynamic that raises a crucial question: does rejecting the maternal bond inevitably entail a rejection of self?

Margaret Mahler's separation-individuation theory offers a framework for understanding the tension between Lucy's need for autonomy and her dependence on her mother. It explores how children gradually develop an individual identity and become independent of their primary caregivers. The process of self-formation and childhood development involves the fulfilment of emotional, psychological and physical needs by the mother during the symbiotic phase (approximately 2–5 months). Mahler defines this crucial developmental stage as follows: "the infant behaves and functions as though he and his mother were an omnipotent system—a dual unity within one common boundary. [...] The normal symbiotic phase marks the all-important phylogenetic capacity of the human being to invest the mother within a vague dual unity that forms the primal soil from which all subsequent human relationship form".[37] The symbiotic phase represents the infant's close connection with and need for their mother. This primal soil is critical for establishing a secure sense of self, shaping emotional needs, experiences and responses that influence human relationship patterns. As Jane Flax asserts that "[t]he developmental task in this phase is to establish a strong bond with the mother. Later experiences cannot completely compensate for inadequacies in this period. The symbiotic bond provides grounding, the sense of ontological security, on which the infant can rely as it moves out of the symbiotic orbit into differentiation and exploration of the outside world".[38] Without an intense emotional connection with her mother, Lucy cannot feel secure in exploring herself and the outside world. As there is no sufficiently nurturing bond between Lucy and her mother, later experiences cannot compensate for this initial lack, which may result in traumatic experiences and ontological insecurity.

Stemming from her disrupted symbiotic phase, Lucy's ontological insecurity resurfaces in adulthood through her interpretation of familial imagery when she sees an unnamed statue of a man with his children at the Metropolitan Museum of Art. Lucy reads the placard and learns that "these children are offering themselves as food for their father, he is being starved to death in prison, and these children only want one thing—to have their father's distress disappear. They will allow him—oh, happily, happily—to eat them".[39] This statue—the famous statue of Ugolino and Sons[40]—embodies unhealthy and dysfunctional family relations, in which children sacrifice themselves to assuage their father's suffering. Strout uses this unsettling image not merely as a literary allusion but as a symbolic representation of how children internalise parental suffering, even to their own detriment. Derived from Dante's *Inferno*, the story of the statue metaphorically represents Lucy's childhood trauma and illuminates the novel's exploration of intergenerational trauma. Rather than being protected by their parents, Lucy and her siblings are forced to confront parental pain.

[37]Mahler, *The Psychological Birth of the Human Infant: Symbiosis and Individuation*, 44–8.
[38]Flax, "The Conflict between Nurturance and Autonomy in Mother-Daughter Relationship within Feminism", 173.
[39]Strout, *My Name is Lucy Barton*, 87.
[40]The sculpture, Ugolino and Sons, takes its story from Dante's *Inferno* and depicts the fall of Count Ugolino, accused of treason and imprisoned in a tower with his sons and grandsons to starve to death. Lucy depicts the statue in a detailed way: "It is a marble statue of a man with his children near him, and the man has such desperation on his face and the children at his feet appear to be clinging, begging him, while he gazes out toward the world with a tortured look, his hands pulling at his mouth, but his children look only at him" (Ibid., 86–7).

The sacrifice of Ugolino's sons reflects Lucy's efforts to comprehend, excuse and mitigate her parents' suffering, especially her father's brutality and her mother's emotional withdrawal. Strout, here, explores how deeply ingrained trauma manifests through symbolic representations. Thus, the story of Ugolino and Sons reveals the contradictions between familial love and violence while reflecting Lucy's struggle to express her traumatic past. The statue mirrors the extreme poverty and self-sacrifice that engulfed Lucy and her siblings; they lived in their great-uncle's garage until Lucy was eleven, lacking basic amenities such as adequate heating, insulation, lighting, hot water and beds. During severe winters, Lucy was so cold that she was often unable to sleep. Her mother gave her hot water bottles. These spatial memories become psychologically significant, representing both physical deprivation and emotional imprisonment. When Lucy comes home for Thanksgiving during her college days, the house triggers profound anxiety: "I could not fall asleep that night [...] I was afraid that I would wake and find myself once more in this house and I would be in this house forever, and it seemed unbearable to me".[41] The house represents her past and childhood traumas. She is afraid of never being able to free herself from her house and escaping this painful, traumatic past.

This sense of entrapment is intensified when Lucy's desperate need for a caring mother-daughter relationship remains unmet. As Anne Fogarty states, "[...] [t]he lost link with the mother appears to be the fundament of a female identity that revolves around a paralysing sense of estrangement and difference".[42] When her doctor tells Lucy she may need surgery, her mother immediately sees this as an opportunity to escape from responsibility: "[i]t's time for me to go home".[43] Yet this is the day that Lucy needs her mother the most. Lucy's subsequent inability to recall a maternal kiss —"I have no idea if she kissed me goodbye [...] I have no memory of my mother ever kissing me. She may have kissed me though; I may be wrong"[44]—emphasises how this absence of maternal warmth fosters an intense longing for care. Through literature, Lucy discovers that books offer her emotional worlds where maternal care and bonding are possible. She finds peace in these fictional worlds, which enables her to escape her family troubles and explore the maternal love she lacked in her childhood. Immersing herself in alternative realities through reading thus becomes Lucy's way of understanding her own existence and escaping the harsh realities of her relationship with her mother, as she recounts:

> In third grade I read a book that made me want to write a book. This book was about two girls and they had a nice mother, and they went to stay in a different town for the summer, and they were happy girls. In this new town there was a girl named Tilly—Tilly!— who was strange and unattractive because she was dirty and poor, and the girls were not nice to Tilly, but the nice mother made them be good to her. This is what I remember from the book: Tilly.[45]

The book means so much to Lucy that she buys it for her own daughter, Chrissie. She feels a strong connection to Tilly in terms of her struggles with the problematic family

[41]Ibid., 26.
[42]Fogarty, "The Horror of the Unlived Life: Mother-Daughter Relationship in Contemporary Irish Women's Fiction", 102.
[43]Strout, *My Name is Lucy Barton*, 137.
[44]Ibid., 138.
[45]Ibid., 24.

dynamics, poverty and life itself. Tilly's name evokes a sense of happiness and liveliness. Lucy wants to feel the happiness of family love and care. The mother in the book is the one who not only looks after her daughters but also teaches them how to be kind to Tilly—a warmth that Lucy would have dearly desired.

Lucy escapes familial imprisonment, builds a life for herself and succeeds in becoming a writer. However, she remains haunted by the absence of a secure maternal bond and a profound sense of loss. As Mirosław Aleksander Miernik notes, "her childhood poverty and the ostracism to which it leads continue to affect her and her social life. This is visible throughout her adolescence, but also as she leaves Amgash to pursue an education, and finally moves to New York City, gradually realizing the American Dream for herself".[46] Yet, this success cannot overcome her enduring trauma. Lucy articulates this pain: "[o]nce in a while I see a child crying with the deepest of desperation, and I think it is one of the truest sounds a child can make. I feel almost, then, that I can hear within me the sound of my own heart breaking [...]".[47] This passage powerfully conveys how Lucy's childhood trauma persists throughout her adulthood.

Lucy's maternal deprivation reaches its climax when her mother, on the point of dying, asks her to leave. Her mother, at her most vulnerable moment, relinquishes a final opportunity to form an emotional bond with her daughter. "I need you to leave,"[48] she says quietly, and her voice remains composed. Lucy recalls, "I heard no anger in her voice. I heard her decisiveness. But truly, I felt panic [... .] "Mommy, I love you!" I called out. I was facing the hallway, but her bed was the closest to me, and she would have heard me, I am sure. I waited. There was no answer, no sound. I tell myself she heard me. I tell myself—I've told myself—this many times".[49] Lucy's panicked and frightened cry for her mother's love, met by unresponsive silence, represents the culmination of Lucy's lifelong deprivation of maternal love. Her mother's death destroys any final chance of healing and reconciliation and her silence leaves Lucy emotionally distraught, uncertain and insecure. This emotional deprivation causes her to question at different times of her life. One of the moments of intense self-questioning is as follows:

> Why did I not just ask her then? Why did I not just say, Mom, I learned all the words I needed to right in that *fucking* garage we called home? I suspect I said nothing because I was doing what I have done most of my life, which is to cover for the mistakes of others when they don't know they have embarrassed themselves [...] I know faintly, even now, that I have embarrassed myself, and it always comes back to the feeling of childhood, that huge pieces of knowledge about the world were missing that can never be replaced (emphasis in original).[50]

The memory of the garage as their home highlights a dual deprivation: emotional insecurity characterised by familial disaffection and violence, and physical inadequacy as a shelter devoid of basic amenities. Her recognition that "huge pieces of knowledge about the world are irrevocably lost" emphasises irretrievable gaps in her emotional

[46]Miernik, *Rethinking Fiction after the 2007/8 Financial Crisis: Consumption, Economics, and the American Dream*, 93.
[47]Strout, *My Name is Lucy Barton*, 59.
[48]Ibid.,164–5.
[49]Ibid., 164–5.
[50]Ibid., 111–2.

development. This awareness reveals an unhealed emotional wound and her inability to articulate her pain directly to its source.

This unresolved trauma profoundly impacts Lucy's artistic development. Writing becomes her primary means of understanding the fraught mother-daughter relationship while also creating a space for self-construction and artistic formation. Functioning not merely as a therapeutic release but as a form of artistic insight, writing transforms Lucy's childhood trauma into narrative art. Thus, her relationship with her mother, marked by direct confrontation with maternal coldness, becomes the source of her creativity and storytelling. Through this narrative process, Lucy reclaims the power to express what was long silenced and re-forms her personal pain into artistic expression. Her artistic awakening occurs when she realises that her relationship with her mother embodies both trauma and creativity. The inherent silences and emotional gaps between them foster her writing. Lucy's decision to bring the sketches, which she has been working on since her earlier encounter with Sarah Payne in the library, to Sarah's workshop represents an important moment in Lucy's artistic journey. By sharing intimate memories of her mother's hospital visit, Lucy demonstrates how writing serves as a means to explore the mother-daughter relationship, a desire for self-healing, and an inner journey of reconciliation with her mother. This process intensifies when Lucy realises Sarah suffers from PTSD. Sarah, acting as an artistic mentor rather than merely an emotional surrogate mother figure, mediates Lucy's self-discovery by encouraging her to explore and illuminate her traumatic past. This excavation promotes both psychological healing and artistic development, which fosters Lucy's emergence as a writer and her growth as a woman and daughter who achieves to name, narrate and reconcile with her traumatic past. Reframed through artistic expression, trauma may become a source of creative power rather than solely a psychological burden. The mother-daughter relationship, once defined by silence and maternal deprivation, is reconfigured through Lucy's art into a generative force that shapes her identity and facilitates healing.

The novel presents writing as Lucy's primary means of reconciling with her past. Her sketches about her mother's hospital visit enable her to reimagine and reconstruct their bond through narrative. This artistic process enables reconciliation impossible through direct confrontation. The maternal absence and silence thus transform into creative presence that generates her artistic voice. Her writing career enables Lucy to process, transform and recontextualise trauma. Yet Lucy's process of self-discovery is not confined to her writing alone; it extends into her marriage and motherhood, where the effects of trauma continue to manifest.

Lucy's father opposed her marriage to William because William's resemblance to one of the two German boys he had killed during the war triggered his war traumas. He suffered from severe and prolonged PTSD and never passed a day without thinking about them or entertaining suicidal thoughts. However, Lucy defied her family and married William, seeking a family of her own and a new sense of belonging. She continued her marriage until her parents' deaths. Her profound fear of abandonment overwhelmed her: "the world began to look different to me. My husband seemed a stranger, my children in their adolescence seemed indifferent to much of my world. I was really lost. I could not stop feeling panic".[51] When she divorced, she realised she

[51]Ibid., 167.

transmitted this primal fear of abandonment and insecurity to her daughters: "[f]or I am the one who left their father, even though at the time I really thought I was just leaving *him*. But that was foolish thinking, because I left my girls as well, and I left their home" (emphasis in original).[52] Lucy's decision to end her marriage marks a generational shift. Unlike her mother, trapped in an abusive relationship by economic dependence and patriarchal norms, Lucy had the freedom to leave a marriage that no longer fulfilled her. Although burdened by guilt for leaving her daughters behind, she prioritised her emotional wellbeing over social expectations of marital endurance. This conflict between personal freedom and maternal guilt lingered in her relationship with her daughters, gradually softened during the 9/11 attacks.

The day the planes crashed into the World Trade Centre was a huge source of global trauma, and almost 3000 people were killed. It marks a significant traumatic moment for Lucy and her daughter, Becka. Lucy vividly recalls her daughter's cry: "I heard Becka cry out, "*Mommy*!" [...] Privately I think only of my daughter on that day. Never have I heard before or since that particular cry of her voice. *Mommy*" (emphasis in original).[53] This cry symbolises a primal fear of abandonment and insecurity and transforms a global trauma into a personal trauma for Lucy's daughter. This is the wailing and screaming of a daughter who wants to be protected by her mother in times of threat. This event profoundly affects Lucy, leading her sometimes to utter 'Mommy' herself when alone at home. She is uncertain whether she calls out to her dead mother or hears Becka's cry. This ambivalence shows how Lucy feels in a traumatic moment: Lucy is a mother who must protect her daughters, yet simultaneously a daughter who desperately needs maternal protection. This shared trauma creates a moment of emotional vulnerability and reconnects the mother and the daughter. Then Lucy thinks she hears them both: Becka's cry and her own cry for her mother, and states: "this is my story. And yet it is the story of many. It is Molla's story, my college roommate's, it may be the story of the Pretty Nicely Girls. *Mommy*. Mom! But this one is my story. This one. And my name is Lucy Barton" (emphasis in original).[54] Acknowledging that the mother-daughter relationships are complex and fraught with trauma and anxiety, Lucy realises that her relationship with her mother is unique yet also universal—a collective trauma and the story of many. As Malina Załużna-Łuczkiewicz emphasises, "people's fates are intertwined and mutually dependent but through this final sentence the narrator asserts herself, establishes her own, separate identity". [55]

Arguably, larger political and cultural discourses have shaped this collective consciousness of trauma and made it a global issue. Patriarchal systems oppress women by silencing and imposing certain gendered roles. Mothers shaped by patriarchal, political, and cultural systems transfer the same burdens and traumas to their daughters. A troubled, traumatic mother-daughter relationship driven by fear, anxiety and insecurity is the story of many. Lucy's journey of self-discovery through her desire to confront, reject and reconcile with the lack of her mother is unique yet serves this collective experience of the mother-daughter relationship.

[52]Ibid., 184.
[53]Ibid., 187–8.
[54]Ibid., 189.
[55]Załużna-Łuczkiewicz. "Secrets and Silences – finding a voice to speak the unspeakable in Elizabeth Strout's *My Name is Lucy Barton*", 61.

I have focused on the overarching themes of how identification with and separation from the mother functions in the transmission of intergenerational trauma in the mother-daughter relationship within *My Name is Lucy Barton*. The novel explores the tale of a daughter caught between longing for a maternal reconciliation and an angry rejection of her mother shaped by childhood trauma—a trauma passed on by Lucy's mother's own traumatic past. Cycles of abuse are self-perpetuating. (Un)spoken and (un)defined intergenerational trauma passed down through the generations is of paramount importance in shaping daughters' identities and relationships. Trauma that manifests itself in silence, the impossibility of mutual, loving communication with the mother, and a sense of detachment and profound loneliness shape Lucy's self-discovery and underline the difficulty of breaking out of this cycle. Lucy uses the stories of her friends' traumatic relationships with their mothers to distance herself from her own trauma and to emphasise the fact that this is the story of many, and one that will never end. Elizabeth Strout's novel creates a space for other mother-daughter relationships to be heard, told and written.

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